Anthem, M-80 and Parked Car

By Jim Daniels

INTRODUCITON

A boy learns from his father, without even realizing he's doing it, what a man is and does. Fathers undoubtedly have a powerful influence on their growing sons. It begins from the moment of birth and continues throughout their lives. This poetry collection by Jim Daniels begins when the author realizes that he can see his father through the eyes of another and recognizes love for the first time. Anthem by Jim Daniels

Anthem

Two months after retirement
my father is here, to get away
from 6 A.M. and his cup
of empty destination.

At a football game, we huddle
under his flimsy umbrella

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talking about the obvious.
He brings me coffee
to hold warm between my hands,
a gift of no occasion.

When we rise for the anthem
I hear the rusty crack of his voice
for the first time maybe ever.

Thirty-three years of coughing
thick factory air, of drifting to sleep
through the heavy ring of machinery,
of twelve-hour days. In my sleep
I felt the cold bump of his late-night kiss.

I shiver in the rain
as my father sings me
what now I hear
as a children's song. I lean
into him, the umbrella and rain
my excuse, my shoulder

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against his, and I imagine my mother
falling in love.

TRANSITION

Falling in love – if parents can do it, then it's certainly possible for a 12-old-boy to fall in love . . . Right? This next selection focuses on the author's first crush which just happened to coincide with his 12th birthday and the assignation of Robert Kennedy. Seems like for a 12-year-old everything is a small explosion – like an M-80.

M-80

ROBERT KENNEDY SHOT. Early June
my mother prayed the rosary
in front of the hollow crucifix in her room
that slid open to reveal death candles
hidden for last rites' blessing.
They'd get used soon enough.

She prayed a long time. My father
wanted dinner. We ate mac and cheese.

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Wipe your mouth
you've got that orange stuff all over it.
You're a big boy now–try to eat right.
A day when everything stuck to my face,
my 12th birthday. *Postponed,*
my mother whispered through tears.

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Bobby. Bobby Kennedy, Debbie said,
balancing on the curb. She wore
a white blouse, shirttail out over cutoffs.
She drew a blue heart on her tennis shoe.
I wanted to fill it in.

What could we do
in the gray light of clouds
and broken glass, the stale wads
of gum clutching our teeth?
It was after a rain and we rode through puddles

it was a banana-seat stingray
it was one speed and one speed only.
She rode behind me on the seat
her thin legs swaying just above the ground.

We bought Twinkies and Orange Crushes,
I said *I have an orange crush on you.*
She laughed.
My birthday got rained out, I told her.
Assassinated. Our laughs short,
hollow. *Why does everybody*
hate everybody? Debbie asked.
Her parents had just split.
I don't hate you, I said.

Look at you, she said and put down
her Crush, licked the cream around my lips.
An M-80 went off in my chest–at least
it seemed that way. I'd bought five of them
from Artie Pilkowski, saving them for the 4th.

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But I would use one soon enough
to blow up a mailbox–I was not immune.
Artie lost part of his hand that summer,
another of those hard-way lessons
we kept hearing about.

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Behind the store we held each other and kissed
birthday kisses even after it was dark
even after it rained some more.

I kicked up my kickstand and rode her home
under the blue streetlights. She held on
tighter than I've ever been held.
My brother stood on the corner
smoking with his friends.
Junior's got a girlfriend, they said.
We were fierce and serious as I pedaled past.

My mother was praying again, and the TV was off.
I knelt beside her, my elbows sinking
into the soft bed, offering up
my small explosions.

TRANSITION

But small explosions turn to life changing explosions as we grow older. It's then that love becomes much more complicated and sometimes it take the love a friend to help us see our way through the emotional turmoil. We end today with Jim Daniels' Parked Car.

Parked Car

Fred and I . . .
drove around laughing like we did
in the old days before I met Karen.
Then I said *drive by Karen's*
and he said *are you sure?*
Then he said *okay* like he was tired
and didn't want to end up

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bailing me out again.
She'd given my ring back a month ago.
I knew she had a date.

A car was parked where I always parked.
Fred pulled in on the other side of the street.
We sat there. *There's no one in the car*
Fred said. *No one in the car.*
No lights in the house. I squinted hard
through the dark, saw a head
pop up above the seat then down again.
I reached for the door.
There's no one in the car --
we're leaving now, Fred said.
He put his hand on my shoulder
gentle and firm.

******

I turned to stone then crumbled
wanting her and not wanting her
while Fred drove me home.

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I held my open hand out the window
against the cold wind.

25 years ago.
Today in a moment rain
changes to snow.
Maybe it was Fred I loved that night.
We would have never called it that.
And I still wouldn't to his face --
that small touch
during the years none of us
ever touched each other.

Sometimes I still drive by that spot
with my wife who doesn't know the ghost
living there. We don't kiss in cars anymore
Karen's married, moved away.

Ah, heart. Hearts.
Mine and yours. Yeah, all of you.
the times we've given it away

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for chump change.
The heart, the fist. If you're lucky
someone grabs your shoulder.

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SOURCE INFORMATION FOR ALL

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AWARD HISTORY

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****added additional poems to create a program due to short length of "M-80"***